

Do not split blindly at the level of individual rows. Ten questions rewritten from the same warranty paragraph belong together; otherwise the model may effectively encounter the test answer during training. Group related examples by source document, customer case or time period before dividing them.

Similarly, if your task concerns updated policies, reserve newer documents for testing how well the system handles changes. Never use test results repeatedly to choose prompts or tune hyperparameters: the test set becomes another development set, and the score loses meaning.

For a RAG application, keep the distinction clear. The source knowledge base may legitimately contain the policy whose facts must be retrieved, while your evaluation questions and reference answers remain separate. You are evaluating retrieval and answer quality, not asking the system to guess facts it was forbidden to access.

Synthetic data: useful but not self-validating

Once your human-written examples look good, an existing local model can help you scale coverage. Give it one approved policy section and ask for five distinct customer questions: a straightforward query, an exception, a comparison, an ambiguous request and an unanswerable question. Require it to cite the specific passage supporting every proposed answer.

Then review each pair against the original. Reject invented clauses, unsupported dates and questions whose wording accidentally reveals the answer. Edit duplicates and maintain a record of whether an example was human-authored or model-generated.

Synthetic data is particularly handy for varying expression: "refund kab milega?" and "When will my refund arrive?" might represent the same intent. But never assume generated Hindi or Hinglish is naturally idiomatic without a fluent reviewer. Automated generation can multiply mistakes just as efficiently as it multiplies examples.

Use synthetic cases to widen coverage, not to replace authoritative sources or genuine user behaviour.

Privacy, rights and the final inspection

Data you possess is not necessarily data you are entitled to train on or disclose. Before indexing emails, support tickets or employee documents, identify names, phone numbers, personal addresses, payment details, credentials and confidential contracts. Remove what the application does not need; restrict access to the remainder.

Tools such as Microsoft Presidio can assist with detecting and anonymising personal information, but its own documentation warns that automated detection misses some sensitive content. Human checks remain essential, especially for Indian identifiers and mixed-language material.



India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and the notified 2025 Rules also make personal-data governance relevant to AI projects; obligations and commencement dates require attention. Review lawful purpose, notices, retention and applicable contractual restrictions instead of assuming "it stays local" settles every question. Public availability does not automatically confer copyright permission. Check dataset and document licences, attribution duties and redistribution limits.

Finally, write a manifest listing source counts, languages, versions, flagged records and dataset splits. Keep sensitive material out of public repositories and cloud services unless you have permission and appropriate safeguards. A dataset you can audit, update and delete is far more valuable than a mysterious folder labelled `final_v7`.